

THE CREATURE BEFORE GOD

Part II

The Due Return

Religion and the Justice of Creaturehood

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1 From Gift to Return

Part I ended with the judgment *God loves*. That conclusion makes the asymmetry harder, not easier. God needs nothing; the creature has nothing unreceived. An equal return is impossible. Yet knowingly to receive the good and remain indifferent is already to take a position toward its giver.

Repayment is therefore the wrong model from the start. The relevant return neither enriches God nor pretends that the creature stands outside what it has received. It concerns the truthfulness of creaturely action: whether intellect, will, body, time, and goods are ordered in accord with a relation to God that the creature did not make.

In Psalm 116, this problem assumes liturgical form. “How can I repay the Lord?” (v. 12). The psalmist answers not with a possession transferred into divine ownership, but by receiving the cup, calling upon the Lord’s name, fulfilling his vows, and giving thanks in the presence of the people (vv. 13–19). Return begins, paradoxically, with reception.

St. Paul excludes any return that would make God a debtor. “Who has given [God] anything that he may be repaid?” His answer is absolute: no one. “From him and through him and for him are all things” (Rom 11:35–36). No creature reaches behind the first gift or supplies a divine lack. Whatever return means, it cannot mean repayment.

2 Worship before the God Who Needs Nothing

Any account of worship that supplies a need in God reverses the relation it means to confess. If sacrifice or obedience completed something missing in the divine life, the Creator would depend upon the creature. Worship would no longer tell the truth about either one.

Irenaeus denies that divine service answers a need in God. God did not form Adam because he needed a human being upon whom to depend. Before creation, the Word glorified the Father. Nor did God command service because he needed human obedience. Those who follow the light do not illuminate it; they are illuminated. Service profits God nothing, while the servant receives life, incorruption, and communion with God (*Against Heresies* IV.14.1–2). His account of sacrifice follows the same order. God does not hunger for oblations. He teaches a people to turn from idols, to practice justice, and to offer from a rightly ordered heart (IV.17.1; 18.1–6).

We do not serve to supply a lack in God; we serve because we lack God. Worship brings no gain to the One worshipped. It directs the worshipper toward communion with the good that no creature can produce for itself.

In Aquinas’s account of religion, we offer not for God’s usefulness but for his glory and our good (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 6, ad 2). “Glory” here is not an increase in divine excellence. It is the creature’s manifestation and acknowledgment of an excellence already infinite. Right worship creates no new truth about God; it brings the worshipper’s act into conformity with truth.

2.1 Gratitude without indifference

God owes no creature the original gift of existence. Aquinas nevertheless distinguishes the orders carefully. God is not directed to creatures as to an end that perfects him. Within the order willed by divine wisdom, however, God gives each created nature what belongs to its condition; created dues are real but derivative (ST I, q. 21, a. 1, ad 3). The creature likewise possesses goods, powers, relations, and ends from which genuine obligations follow.

Creation begins with no antecedent claim in a nonexistent recipient. Once a rational creature exists, however, it is capable of acting fittingly or unfittingly toward the source from whom it exists. It can acknowledge truth or suppress it, honor the good or prefer a lesser good as ultimate, render justice or withhold it. The gratitude of the first gift does not leave moral life shapeless.

Gratitude excludes contract without producing moral indifference. God does not create in order to exact an equivalent, but neither does the freedom of the gift leave the relation without moral form. Obligation can arise within a relation that is neither commercial nor initiated by the one obliged. Gratitude and due are not contraries.

The relation to God is more radical and less commensurable. Everything offered is already received: the body that kneels, the reason that judges, the will that consents, the bread and wine placed upon the altar, the hour reserved for worship. Nothing crosses from an independent estate into divine possession. The return cannot make the accounts

equal because there are no such accounts.

The giver cannot be enriched, and the return cannot be equal; nevertheless, the creature can render or withhold what is fitting.

3 Justice without Equivalence

A ledger cannot settle this return. The creature has nothing independent to give, God cannot be enriched, and no exchange can close the relation. Yet something is truly due. Religion belongs to justice under a peculiar condition: the due is real, while equality of exchange is impossible.

3.1 The will to render the due

Aquinas receives the classical juristic definition of justice as the constant and enduring will to render to each one his right. The definition joins an objective term—what is due to another—to a subjective firmness—the will that knowingly and steadily renders it (ST II–II, q. 58, a. 1). Justice is not satisfied by a correct idea retained within the intellect. It rectifies action toward another.

God is not “another” alongside creatures within one common genus. Yet a rational creature is really distinct from God and really ordered to him. The special virtue governing acts of honor toward God is religion. It offers sacrifice, adoration, prayer, vows, and related acts because God alone is the first principle of creation and government and the last end of rational life (ST II–II, q. 81, aa. 1–4).

Religion belongs to justice, but not as a part capable of exact equality. Aquinas places it among justice’s potential parts: something is genuinely due, but the full equality of strict justice cannot be achieved because the recipient infinitely exceeds the giver and the return can never equal the gift (q. 80, a. 1; q. 81, a. 5). The shortfall is not a defect in a willing creature’s virtue. Equality is measured according to the creature’s capacity and God’s acceptance, not as equivalence between independent parties (q. 81, a. 5, ad 3).

An equal return is impossible. A true return is not.

3.2 Obligation without coercion

Obligation is not identical with constraint. Aquinas distinguishes a necessity arising from constraint, which acts against the will, from the necessity of a command or of a means required for an end. The second does not destroy merit when one voluntarily does what is necessary (ST II–II, q. 58, a. 3, ad 2). Likewise, the service owed to God can be virtuous precisely insofar as it is rendered willingly (q. 81, a. 2, ad 2).

Duty is therefore neither self-creation nor alien coercion. The will does not invent the good by choosing it, but neither is a forced bodily movement an act of virtue. A just act is knowingly chosen for a due end and performed with stability. Obligation can bind the will without forcing it.

Consent does not produce the Creator’s authority; nevertheless, the creature’s moral act becomes whole only through consent. A person can attend worship to preserve a reputation, recite words without attention, or avoid external wrongdoing while inwardly preferring injustice. The external act may retain some objective order, but virtue requires the will’s truthful participation.

Aquinas calls the will’s readiness for divine service *devotion*. Devotion is not first an intensity of feeling. It is the act by which one gives oneself readily to what pertains to God’s service (ST II–II, q. 82, aa. 1–2). The readiness is inward but not disembodied: the will made ready for divine service must act through the body it has received.

4 The Living Sacrifice

Paul’s “therefore” joins the denial that anyone first gives to God, the confession that all things are from him and through him and for him, and the mercy that precedes response: the creature is to offer the body as a living sacrifice

(Rom 11:35–12:1). The offering neither repairs a divine lack nor transfers an independently possessed good into God’s estate. The body offered is already created; the reason renewed is already sustained; the will that consents already acts through powers it has received.

Sacrifice makes the return visible. Aquinas argues that natural reason recognizes some outward sign of the honor and subjection due to the first principle, while positive law determines its concrete forms. Embodied signs subject the mind to God and can arouse the devotion they express; the outward offering signifies the inward sacrifice in which the soul offers itself to God (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 7; q. 85, aa. 1–2). The sign is false when it is severed from the inward act, but the inward act is not therefore disembodied. An embodied and social creature answers with more than an intention hidden from the world.

For Augustine, every work truly ordered to holy fellowship with God is sacrifice; the person becomes an offering, works of mercy are referred to the supreme good, and the whole redeemed city is offered through the High Priest who first offered himself (*City of God* X.5–6, 20). Christian self-offering is not an autonomous ascent. It occurs within Christ’s prior oblation.

The Eucharist is not deduced from First-Mover metaphysics. Christ’s sacrifice is a genuinely human oblation offered by the divine Son; it cannot be placed alongside creaturely returns as though commensurable with them. Christ is priest and victim; the Church’s self-offering depends wholly upon his perfect prior oblation. United to him, she offers the divine Victim and learns to offer herself with him (*Sacrosanctum Concilium* 47–48; *Lumen Gentium* 10–11). Work and prayer, family life and rest, hardship and acts of mercy become spiritual sacrifices when offered through Christ and brought into his Eucharistic offering (*Lumen Gentium* 34).

A living sacrifice takes the received self as its matter: intellect, will, body, time, possessions, and common life. It does not merely acknowledge that creaturely being is from God. It places creaturely action within that truth.

Because Christian sacrifice is ecclesial, its words, signs, times, and offices are received rather than privately devised. Authority belongs inside the account of worship; its presence does not by itself convert command into coercion.

5 Command within Deliverance

The Decalogue does not begin with a naked imperative. God first identifies himself through an act of deliverance: “I, the Lord, am your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, that place of slavery.” Only then follows “You shall” (Exod 20:2–3). The law does not address an anonymous will in an empty universe. It addresses a people already created, rescued, assembled, and claimed.

The order does not reduce command to gratitude. The commandments state genuine goods and prohibit genuine evils. Nor does it make obedience the price by which liberation is purchased after the fact. It shows the identity of the Lawgiver and the relation within which the law is heard. The one who commands is not Pharaoh under another name. He is the one who has broken Pharaoh’s claim.

The *Catechism* preserves this order. The Decalogue is understood within covenant and as a response to God’s initiative; moral existence answers a loving action that comes first (CCC 2060–2062). The first word recalls liberation before it makes the just demand that Israel accept and worship the one God (CCC 2084). At Sinai, covenantal gift precedes commanded response. Command is not severed from gift, and gift is not made morally mute.

5.1 Natural law disclosed and taught

The commandments are revealed, yet their moral substance is not arbitrary. Aquinas argues that the moral precepts of the Old Law belong to the natural law: they concern acts whose order to human good can be known by reason (ST I–II, q. 100, a. 1). Revelation gives them divine promulgation, gathers them into covenant, corrects a reason darkened in practice, and directs them within salvation history.

Theft and murder did not become wrong only when words were inscribed on tablets. Yet revelation is not superfluous merely because reason can in principle know moral truth. Human beings require instruction, correction, authority, and grace. The Decalogue states with divine clarity an order that belongs to the good of rational creatures.

Aquinas treats its precepts as primary specifications of justice. The general commands to love God and neighbor order the whole law; the Decalogue gives immediately knowable conclusions and directs acts toward the due (q. 100,

a. 3). The first table orders the person to the common and final good, God. The second establishes justice among persons, forbidding what is undue and commanding that each receive the due (q. 100, a. 8).

5.2 Moral substance and specified observance

The Sabbath command displays another distinction. For Aquinas, its moral core is that a person should reserve some time for divine things. The determination of a particular time and ceremonial manner does not follow from natural reason alone (ST I–II, q. 100, a. 3, ad 2; a. 7, ad 5; II–II, q. 122, a. 4). The Christian Lord’s Day therefore cannot be read off from natural reason or treated as a simple continuation of every Mosaic Sabbath determination. Its Resurrection-centered meaning is received from revelation and apostolic tradition; its determinate common observance comes through ecclesiastical law (CCC 2174–2177).

Natural moral obligation, revealed command, and ecclesiastical determination must therefore be distinguished. The obligation to worship does not by itself identify the day and liturgical act current law requires, the persons it binds, the exceptions it recognizes, or the authorities competent to dispense or commute it. Metaphysics establishes no hidden canon; concrete observance must be identified from competent law.

6 Dependence, Duty, Precept, and Culpability

Dependence, duty, precept, and culpability can converge in one act without becoming the same judgment. Collapse them, and metaphysics begins to issue canons while the bare existence of a canon is made to decide guilt. Four registers keep the claims distinct. Dependence names what is true of the creature whether or not it consents. Duty concerns the act practical reason judges fitting. A precept gives a duty, or one determinate way of fulfilling it, juridical form for identified subjects and circumstances. Culpability concerns the knowledge, freedom, intention, and circumstances of the particular agent.

Their separation establishes important limits. Dependence upon God does not by itself yield the canon specifying how the Sunday precept is fulfilled. A precept identifies an objective obligation without making every external failure equally culpable. That an act is owed does not make it coerced, meritorious without consent, or incapable of love.

6.1 The layers of law

The movement from duty to common form requires authority. Law is an ordinance of reason for the common good, made and promulgated by one who has care of the community (ST I–II, q. 90). Aquinas’s categories of eternal, natural, divine, and human law do not name four independent legislatures occupying one plane. Eternal law is divine wisdom ordering acts and ends. Natural law is the rational creature’s participation in that order through practical reason. Divine positive law is used here for precepts revealed and promulgated by God within salvation history. Human positive law, civil or ecclesiastical, makes common determinations through competent authority.

The labels keep three sources of normativity distinct: what practical reason knows, what God has revealed or commanded, and what human authority has enacted for common observance. A single practice can stand under more than one description without the sources becoming interchangeable. A theological reason does not by itself enact a canon; a canon does not exhaust the moral, ecclesial, or sacramental good it protects.

6.2 From general due to common form

Aquinas holds that natural reason dictates some act of reverence for God. That *this* rather than *that* determinate act be required can be established by divine or human law (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 2, ad 3). Sacrifice likewise belongs generically to natural law, while its concrete signs receive positive determination (q. 85, a. 1, ad 1).

The Lord’s Day follows this pattern without becoming a natural-law theorem. Regular outward worship is morally due; revelation and apostolic tradition give Sunday its Paschal identity, while ecclesiastical law gives that observance determinate juridical form. Governing law and moral teaching distinguish impossibility and excuse from dispensation and commutation by competent authority. These are juridical distinctions, not private preference.

A concrete obligation must therefore be identified through its authority, promulgated text, jurisdiction, subjects, circumstances, and permitted relief. Law states an obligation within a reality it did not originate.

7 Sunday: The Day Made Common

7.1 A received day

St. Justin Martyr's second-century account of the Sunday assembly holds together readings, common prayer, Eucharistic thanksgiving, Communion, and aid to those in need (*First Apology* 67). Sunday is the Lord's Day: Christ rose on the first day of the week, and the Christian assembly receives that day as the first feast and sign of the new creation (CCC 2174). The reality later specified by law is already Paschal, sacramental, corporate, and merciful.

The juridical precept is understood from a reality it did not create. Early Christians experienced the Sunday gathering as an inner necessity before later ecclesiastical law gave the duty more explicit universal form (*Dies Domini* 46–48). The Second Vatican Council calls Sunday the original feast day (*Sacrosanctum Concilium* 106). Neither historical spontaneity nor later obligation exhausts the practice.

Because Eucharistic worship is the act of a body rather than an aggregate of private intentions, its common temporal form cannot be generated anew by each individual will. Sunday gives received time a Paschal and ecclesial order. It gathers persons who did not choose one another into one thanksgiving, interrupts labor's claim to ultimacy, and makes room for joy, rest, and mercy. The precept specifies a minimum; it does not measure the fullness of worship or love. A common minimum protects a good that private intentions alone cannot secure.

7.2 What current Latin law actually requires

For the Latin Church, current promulgated law governs the content and limits of the juridical obligation; metaphysical principles alone cannot supply those details. The good exceeds the legal minimum, while the minimum remains precise.

Current universal Latin law gives this good determinate juridical form. The Latin Code binds the persons identified by its general norms (CIC cc. 1 and 11). It names Sunday the primordial holy day of obligation (c. 1246 §1). On that day the faithful are obliged to participate in Mass and to refrain from works and affairs that impede the worship owed to God, the joy proper to the Lord's Day, or suitable rest (c. 1247). The second duty is governed by those goods, not by a universal prohibition of every form of work.

Participation in a Mass celebrated in any Catholic rite on Sunday or the preceding evening satisfies the Mass precept (c. 1248 §1). Reception of Holy Communion is a distinct sacramental and juridical question; the Sunday precept does not require reception at every Sunday Mass. Serious reason, impossibility, and dispensation by competent authority can all affect what is required, each with distinct grounds and effects. The *Catechism* names illness and care of infants as examples of serious reason; the Code treats impossibility and permits competent dispensation or commutation in defined circumstances (CCC 2181; CIC cc. 1245 and 1248 §2). None of these is private self-dispensation, and no general article can decide facts it does not possess.

Objective obligation and personal culpability must likewise be distinguished. Deliberate omission without serious reason concerns grave matter, but mortal culpability additionally requires full knowledge and deliberate consent (CCC 1857–1861, 2181). An external absence alone does not disclose all of those conditions. Questions of jurisdiction, persons bound, territorial holy days, relief, sacramental reception, and individual facts require the governing jurisdiction, applicable particular law, and facts of the individual case; universal law alone does not decide them.

Works of mercy belong positively to the day. Family needs and important social service can justify necessary labor; Christians should also resist imposing avoidable work upon others and attend to those whose poverty denies them ordinary leisure (CCC 2185–2187). The day is not sanctified by making necessary care invisible.

The Sunday precept is therefore an instance of responsive justice, not its exhaustive inventory. Its concern for worship, joy, rest, and mercy prevents observance from closing upon itself. The due rendered to God is not isolated from the due owed to the neighbor.

8 The Neighbor at the Altar

An altar can be made into a border: worship on one side, the remainder of life kept as an independent estate on the other. The prophets and Fathers refuse that division. Irenaeus insists that God neither hungers for offerings nor accepts sacrifice severed from justice (*Against Heresies* IV.17.1; 18.1–6). An external act of religion can be objectively due and still fail to express a self offered to God.

Gregory Nazianzen inventories existence, breath, understanding, knowledge of God, hope, creation's beauty, food, laws, social life, friendship, and the common goods of the earth. Having named what has been received, he identifies the return God asks: kindness and love, rendered through just stewardship toward the poor (*Oration* 14.23–25). The neighbor is not an interruption of the Godward answer. The gift has already placed the neighbor within it.

For Chrysostom, the one who honors Christ's altar while neglecting Christ in the poor contradicts the honor he claims to render. His argument does not oppose beautiful worship to almsgiving; it denies that splendor can excuse abandonment of the afflicted (*Homilies on Matthew* 50.3–4). Justin's Sunday assembly had already joined Eucharistic thanksgiving to a collection for widows, orphans, the sick, prisoners, and strangers (*First Apology* 67).

Christ's sacrifice is perfect; mercy neither replaces the Eucharist nor adds to that sacrifice as though it were deficient. Mercy is a fruit and test of the communicant's incorporation into Christ. Worship directs mercy toward a good the self does not invent; mercy exposes religion confined to a protected interior life as false. The living sacrifice passes through both because body, possessions, and social life are among the goods received.

The upward and outward directions of the due cannot finally be separated. Religion gives God the honor owed to the first principle, but it can command acts elicited by other virtues—showing mercy to the afflicted, acting temperately and truthfully, and rendering justice to the neighbor (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 1, ad 1; a. 4, ad 1). The same God creates worshipper and neighbor; one cannot honor the Creator by treating the creature's due as dispensable. The unseen God tests professed love in the treatment of the person who can be seen (1 John 4:20–21).

Justice therefore does more than add obligations after awe. It gives the apprehension a stable outward grammar: adore, keep faith, tell the truth, render what is due, protect rest, serve the vulnerable. These acts do not make dependence smaller. They make action agree with it.

9 Grace and the Answer

Knowing what is owed is not the same as having the power to render it. Justice names the due; it does not create a natural capacity for supernatural communion. No creature can repay creation or become equal to the Creator; that inequality is permanent. Fallen nature also cannot attain the supernatural end by its own powers.

The *Catechism* says that when God reveals himself and calls, a person cannot fully respond to divine love by his own powers. The person must hope that God will give the capacity to love in return and to act according to charity's commandments (CCC 2090). Aquinas describes hope as tending toward future beatitude, arduous but possible through divine assistance (ST II–II, q. 17, aa. 1–2).

Grace does not erase the permanent inequality. In the sinner, it heals fallen nature and elevates the creature toward the supernatural end. Hope relies upon the divine assistance by which a real answer becomes possible without withdrawing the claim of justice.

The *Catechism* treats presumption and despair as contrary distortions of hope. Presumption appeals to mercy while refusing conversion, or trusts one's own powers as sufficient. Despair treats forgiveness, assistance, or beatitude as unavailable (CCC 2091–2092). Presumption makes obedience unnecessary; despair makes it futile. Both distort the priority of gift.

Devotion joins this hope to the will. For Aquinas, consideration of divine goodness principally awakens readiness and joy; recognition of one's defect excludes presumption and introduces sorrow secondarily, while hope moves the person to rely upon divine help (ST II–II, q. 82, aa. 3–4). Creaturely finitude is not itself a moral defect, and spiritual joy is not a promise of sensible ease. Devotion names the will becoming available for divine service even when the act remains costly or dry.

The First Mover is also the first mover of the return, though the supernatural claim is not deduced from the metaphysical proof. Aquinas holds both that God moves the will according to its voluntary mode and that even a free turning toward grace requires God's gratuitous inward motion (ST I-II, q. 10, a. 4; q. 109, a. 6). The response is received without becoming fictitious. Grace does not answer in place of the creature; it gives the creature the power to answer.

In Gregory Nazianzen's sequence, grace comes first; fear takes determinate form in keeping the commandments; obedience purifies; purification opens toward illumination and the fulfillment of desire (*Oration* 39.8–10). The sequence is neither wages earned for vision nor a technique guaranteed to regulate feeling. It names how received truth can take hold of action and dispose a person for deeper knowledge of God.

The psalmist receives the cup, keeps his vows, and gives thanks among the people. The answer is truly his; even his power to make it has been received.

Justice can remove obstacles to peace, but it does not by itself unify desire in the beloved good (ST II-II, q. 29, a. 3, ad 3). It cannot produce the unity in which a good commanded by the highest Lord is embraced as communion with the beloved.

What is owed can be freely loved. What is freely loved does not cease to be owed. That movement belongs to charity.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and governing profiles

This is Part II of *The Creature Before God*, a discursive series for a serious general reader. Part I, *Ontological Vertigo*, treats the apprehension of asymmetric dependence and the fork of recoil or adoration. This article asks how the response becomes a living sacrifice, how obligation can be freely rendered, how worship takes common form, and how justice passes through the neighbor. The current universal Latin Sunday obligation is a bounded illustration, not the article's principal subject. Part III treats charity and the filial perfection of the return.

The article deliberately combines theology and canon law under the discursive-articles profile. Metaphysics, Scripture, patristic witness, Thomistic moral theology, and authoritative Catholic teaching govern the account of gift, justice, religion, command, grace, hope, and charity. Canon law governs only the identified juridical conclusions. A theological reason does not by itself enact a canon; the existence of a canon does not settle every theological interpretation or personal culpability judgment.

"Due return," "responsive justice," the four-term grammar of dependence, duty, precept, and culpability, and the language of ontological vertigo's ongoing resolution are project synthesis. *Religion* is used principally in Aquinas's technical sense: the moral virtue annexed to justice that renders worship to God. It is not used as a synonym for the theological virtues or for every institutional feature of a religious body.

Source class	Function in the article	Governing boundary
Sacred Scripture	Supplies creation and mercy before response, covenant before command, the Decalogue, worship and justice, the unrepayable gift, and the living sacrifice.	Exegetical synthesis remains bounded by the cited passages; no single verse is made a complete theory of law.
Patristic witness	Shows divine non-need, command for creaturely good, common Sunday worship, grace-enabled obedience, and self-offering in Christ.	Representative witnesses are not a mechanical consensus count or current legislation.
Thomistic theology	Provides justice, religion, unequal due, moral necessity without coercion, devotion, kinds of law, natural and positive determination, grace, hope, and charity's formal role.	School theology and adopted synthesis remain distinct from dogma and current canon law.
Catechetical and conciliar teaching	Governs the doctrinal account of moral law, Church precepts, the Decalogue, the Lord's Day, culpability, hope, worship, and common liturgical life.	The <i>Catechism</i> is authoritative teaching, not the promulgated text of the Latin Code.
Current Latin canon law	Establishes subjects, feast-day duties, satisfaction, impossibility, dispensation, commutation, and territorial competence.	The official Latin text, amendments, jurisdiction, particular law, and facts control; no individual case is adjudicated.
Project synthesis	Orders gift, due, precept, fault, hope, and self-offering into Part II of the series.	The terminology and literary movement are not attributed wholesale to any source.

A.2 Legal scope and currentness

Element	Controlling scope	Limit
Governing body of law	1983 Code of Canon Law as amended; universal law of the Latin Church.	CIC c. 1 excludes applying the Latin Code as such to Eastern Catholics; CCEO c. 881 and proper Eastern law are not analyzed.
Authoritative text and translation	Promulgated Latin and applicable later Latin legislation control; Holy See English pages are working reference renderings.	English wording does not displace the official text, canonical tradition, or a later promulgated norm.
Persons and territory	CIC cc. 1, 11–13 and 1246–1248; no named territory beyond universal law.	Other holy days, dispensations, and observance can depend upon episcopal-conference, diocesan, proper, or other applicable law.
Material facts	Abstract adult Latin Catholic with sufficient use of reason; no serious reason, impossibility, dispensation, commutation, privilege, or special law unless expressly discussed.	Real cases require complete facts and competent pastoral or canonical judgment.
Currentness	Official Code pages, the Holy See code and amendment archive, and the Holy See’s published compilation of authentic interpretations checked through 20 July 2026.	No located amendment or published authentic interpretation modified CIC cc. 1246–1248 in a way material to this article. This bounded audit is not proof against unpublished or unexamined particular or proper law.
Advice boundary	General theological and canonical study.	Not legal or canonical advice, a decree, a culpability judgment, or a substitute for a pastor, confessor, competent authority, or qualified canonist.

A.3 Included and excluded scope

Included are Rom 11:33–12:5, Exod 19–20, Psalm 116, the Decalogue’s twofold order to God and neighbor, Irenaeus on divine non-need, Augustine on true sacrifice, Gregory Nazianzen and Chrysostom on gift and mercy, Justin on the unified Sunday assembly, Aquinas on justice, religion, sacrifice, devotion, grace, and hope, Vatican II on Eucharistic and ordinary self-offering, the *Catechism*’s treatment of Church precepts and Sunday, and current universal Latin law in CIC cc. 1, 11, 85–93, 1244–1248, and 912–923 where separately noted.

Excluded are a comprehensive treatise on moral theology, virtue, conscience, sin, sacramental theology, liturgy, ecclesiology, or canonical interpretation; a calendar of territorial holy days; national conference and diocesan norms; Eastern Catholic law beyond naming the boundary; obligations of clerics or religious arising from office, vows, constitutions, or proper law; remote-participation questions; Eucharistic reception in irregular or disputed circumstances; canonical penalties; and any judgment about a named person’s obligation, excuse, sin, or imputability.

The Sunday case is illustrative, not exhaustive. The Ten Commandments and the Latin Sunday precept do not stand at the same level of authority. The article does not flatten natural moral law, revealed divine law, and ecclesiastical positive law into one inventory.

A.4 Material qualifications

1. Creation is neither compelled by a lack in God nor antecedently owed to a recipient not yet existing. Genuine created dues arise within the order willed by divine wisdom (ST I, q. 21, a. 1, ad 3).
2. “Debt” and “return” are analogical, not commercial. No creature confers actuality, beatitude, or utility upon God or makes God a debtor by worship.

3. Religion is a moral virtue annexed to justice because worship is due but cannot be rendered in absolute equality. It is not itself faith, hope, or charity (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 5).
4. The necessity of command differs from physical or psychological constraint. Obligation does not eliminate voluntariness, while external compliance alone does not constitute complete virtue.
5. Natural reason grounds worship generically; determinate rites and times can arise from divine or human positive law (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 2, ad 3; q. 85, a. 1, ad 1).
6. The Decalogue is revealed and expresses natural moral law. Its moral substance, its covenantal promulgation, and its ceremonial or juridical determinations must be distinguished.
7. Sunday fulfills the Sabbath’s spiritual truth in the Paschal mystery; it is not identified with every Mosaic Sabbath determination (CCC 2174–2176).
8. CIC c. 1247 contains both Mass participation and festal-rest duties. The latter is governed by what impedes worship, joy, works of mercy, and appropriate rest, not by a universal ban on all work.
9. Participation in Mass and reception of Holy Communion are distinct juridical and sacramental questions. CIC cc. 912–923 govern reception; this article decides no sacramental-access case.
10. Excuse, impossibility, dispensation, and commutation have different grounds and effects. Private preference is not competent dispensation.
11. Objective grave matter and mortal culpability are distinct. Full knowledge and deliberate consent must be established; a general article cannot judge a person’s soul (CCC 1857–1861).
12. Violation of a moral or disciplinary norm does not without an applicable penal norm establish a canonical delict or penalty.
13. Hope is not a species of justice. It trusts divine assistance for the arduous supernatural good; presumption and despair each falsify that trust.
14. Grace does not abolish command or secondary agency. The New Law’s inward gift heals and elevates the person to act freely (ST I–II, q. 106, aa. 1–2).
15. Charity perfects and commands the acts of other virtues by ordering them to the final end. It does not make injustice or impiety optional (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 8).
16. The living sacrifice is neither autonomous nor commensurate with Christ’s. The Church’s self-offering depends wholly upon union with her High Priest and Victim and his perfect prior oblation.
17. Worship is not proposed as therapeutic self-management. Its objective truth and formal fruits do not promise sensible calm, and continuing disturbance is not treated as evidence of refusal.
18. The resolution at issue does not reduce dependence. Justice, religion, and hope bring action into agreement with it; charity’s direct unification of desire remains the subject of Part III.

A.5 Translations, rights, and review

Scripture is cited by book and locus, with short working-English phrases checked against the Holy See-hosted NAB witness. Patristic working English comes from identified public-domain ANF or NPNF witnesses. Aquinas is cited by work, part, question, article, and reply; Latin loci are governed by the Corpus Thomisticum, with public English used as an aid. Official Catholic and canonical texts retain their own status. No bulk source text, modern commentary, or source-site wrapper is incorporated.

The legal currentness audit and core online witnesses were checked through 20 July 2026; the newly added patristic, conciliar, and Thomistic loci were checked on 21 July 2026. This is a source-audited working study. It has not received independent scriptural, patristic, Thomistic, moral-theological, liturgical, canonical, literary, or ecclesiastical review. It claims no imprimatur, nihil obstat, legal opinion, or ecclesiastical approval.

B References

Sacred Scripture

- Exod 19:3–6 and 20:1–17; Deut 5:1–22; Psalm 116:1–19, especially vv. 12–19; Matt 22:34–40; John 14:15; Rom 11:33–12:5 and 13:8–10; Jas 1:22–27; 1 John 4:19–21 and 5:3. Short English wording is used as a working rendering; Scripture and translations retain their own status.
- Holy See-hosted New American Bible working witnesses: Exodus 20, Psalm 116, Romans 11, and Romans 12.

Authoritative Catholic witnesses

- Second Vatican Council, constitution *Sacrosanctum Concilium* (4 December 1963), nos. 7, 10–12, 14, 47–48, and 106, on Christ’s sacrifice, the faithful’s self-offering with the divine Victim, liturgical participation, and the Lord’s Day; official English.
- Second Vatican Council, dogmatic constitution *Lumen Gentium* (21 November 1964), nos. 10–11 and 34, on the baptized offering spiritual sacrifices, the faithful offering the divine Victim and themselves with him, and ordinary life offered through Christ; official English.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1730–1748 (freedom and responsibility); 1854–1864 (grave matter and culpability); 1950–1974 (eternal, natural, old, and new law); 2030–2043 (the Church’s moral teaching and precepts); 2060–2082 (covenant, Decalogue, and natural law); 2084–2100 (faith, hope, charity, adoration, prayer, and sacrifice); 2168–2195, especially 2174–2187 (Sabbath, Lord’s Day, Sunday obligation, serious reason, rest, and mercy). Official English pages: culpability, moral law, Church precepts, faith, hope, and charity, and the Lord’s Day.
- St. John Paul II, apostolic letter *Dies Domini* (31 May 1998), especially nos. 6–8, 18–20, 31–34, and 46–53, on the Paschal, ecclesial, moral, and juridical dimensions of Sunday; official English.

Patristic witnesses

- St. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* IV.14.1–2, on divine non-need, service for the creature’s good, and fellowship with God; IV.17.1 and 18.1–6, on sacrifice, justice, and offerings that do not supply a divine need. Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut’s 1885 ANF working English: IV.14, IV.17, and IV.18.
- St. Justin Martyr, *First Apology* 67, on the Sunday assembly, Scripture, common prayer, Eucharistic thanksgiving and Communion, and care of those in need; Marcus Dods and George Reith’s 1885 ANF working English, online witness.
- Augustine, *City of God* X.1, 3, 5–6, and 19–20, on *latria*, true religion, outward signs, every work ordered to holy fellowship with God as sacrifice, the redeemed city offered through Christ, and God as needing no offering; public-domain NPNF working English, online witness.
- St. Gregory Nazianzen, *Oration* 14.23–25, on received existence and created goods answered by kindness, love, and just stewardship toward the poor; Holy See-hosted working excerpt. See also *Oration* 39.8–10, on prior grace, commandment, purification, illumination, and desire; NPNF working English.
- St. John Chrysostom, *Homilies on Matthew* 50.3–4, on honoring Christ’s Eucharistic body without neglecting Christ in the poor and on almsgiving alongside liturgical splendor; public-domain NPNF working English, online witness.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 21, a. 1, especially ad 2–3, and a. 4, ad 4, on divine justice, derivative created dues, and God’s owing no debt to creatures; q. 44, a. 4, on God as final cause.
- Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I–II, q. 10, a. 4 (divine motion according to the voluntary mode); q. 90, aa. 1–4; q. 91, aa. 1–5; q. 94, aa. 1–6 (law, its kinds, and natural law); q. 100, aa. 1, 3, 7, and 8 (the Decalogue, natural law, the two tablets, and moral versus determinate observance); q. 106, aa. 1–2 (the New Law chiefly as inward grace); q. 108, a. 4 (precepts and counsels); q. 109, especially aa. 2–4, 6, and 8 (the need of grace and the graced turning of the will).
- Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* II–II, q. 17, aa. 1–2 (hope and divine assistance); q. 23, a. 8 (charity as form of the virtues); q. 29, a. 3 (justice, charity, and peace); q. 58, aa. 1–4, especially a. 3, ad 2 (justice and necessity of command without constraint); q. 80, a. 1 and q. 81, aa. 1–7 (religion as an unequal part of justice, its acts, and relation to the theological virtues); q. 82, aa. 1–4 (devotion, meditation, joy, and hope); q. 85, aa. 1–4 (sacrifice and natural versus positive determination); q. 122, a. 4 (the Sabbath precept).
- Governing Latin loci checked through the Corpus Thomisticum Leonine-text corpus. The New Advent Summa served as a working public English index; particularly relevant English aids include justice, religion, devotion, the Decalogue, and the New Law. Work and exact locus take precedence over either site’s wording.

Current Latin canon law

- John Paul II, apostolic constitution *Sacrae disciplinae leges* (25 January 1983) and the 1983 *Codex Iuris Canonici* as amended. CIC c. 1 (Latin jurisdiction); cc. 7–22, especially 11–18 (promulgation, persons bound, territory, doubt, interpretation); cc. 85–

93 (dispensations); cc. 912–923 (Eucharistic reception); and cc. 1244–1248 (sacred times, feast days, obligation, satisfaction, impossibility, dispensation, and commutation).

- Official Latin: Book I and Book IV. Holy See-hosted working English: cc. 7–22, cc. 35–93, and cc. 1244–1253.
- Currentness controls checked through 20 July 2026: Holy See Code and amendment archive; Dicastery for Legislative Texts, published compilation of authentic interpretations. No located act amended or authentically interpreted CIC cc. 1246–1248 in a way material to this article.
- Eastern boundary only: CCEO c. 881 contains the Eastern common-law feast-day obligation and preserves the prescriptions or legitimate customs of each Church *sui iuris*. It is not analyzed or replaced by the Latin canons in this article.

C Generation Metadata

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Model: GPT-5-based Codex **agent**; **unexposed:** exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (theological, Thomistic, patristic, canonical, source-audit, drafting, and editorial roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (series-wide grammatical, semantic, theological-weight, literary, source-consistency, drafting, typesetting, and production-review roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (trilogy-wide literary audit, question-led redrafting, theological and canonical source-consistency review, typesetting, and production-review roles); Codex CLI 0.145.0; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (trilogy-wide dramatic-architecture revision, earned-statement redrafting, literary and source-consistency review, typesetting, and production-review roles); Codex CLI 0.145.0; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (trilogy-wide equal-altitude tonal revision, epistemic-order and argumentative-seam editing, philosophical, theological, canonical, literary, source-consistency, typesetting, and production-review roles); Codex CLI 0.145.0; API workspace; unexposed: server revision

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